Black Paintings

By Neil Olson

INTRODUCTION

ERIC: Artists capture reality, truth, beauty in their paintings
DIANE: And agents display and sell these paintings. These bits of reality, truth and beauty.
ERIC: But when the reality and truth are death, what is left to paint?
DIANE: Is death beautiful? Will death sell?
ERIC: When art is death, a painter is left creating
BOTH: "Black Paintings"
DIANE: By Neil Olson

Diane sits center stage at a table upon which there is a small cardboard box. Eric stands stage right at a set of open French doors, looking out.

ERIC: Can you see the ocean from here?

DIANE: Yes.

ERIC: Where do I look?

DIANE: South.

ERIC: Which way is that?

DIANE: The way you're facing.

ERIC: I'm not seeing it.

DIANE: That's right. *(He turns and looks at her in confusion.)* You asked if *I* could see the ocean. There are lovely views from the bedrooms upstairs, but since you will never see those bedrooms, you will never see the ocean from here.

ERIC: Diane.

DIANE: You shouldn't even be in this house.

ERIC: The door was open.

DIANE: There is an acre of private property between the road and that door.

ERIC: And very handsome property it is. Your apple trees are still in bloom,

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they've all gone by in the city. Nice house, too.

DIANE: SO glad you approve.

ERIC: Strange that I've never seen it. I guess Henry only had his top-tier artists out to visit.

DIANE: No.

ERIC: No?

DIANE: This was his refuge. This is where he went to escape the whole crazy, needy lot of you.

ERIC: Sam's been here. He described the place to me.

DIANE: He's a neighbor, that's different.

ERIC: SO just your rich clients, then.

DIANE: Maybe just the loyal ones.

ERIC: Loyal.

DIANE: I'm sorry, did I use an unfamiliar word? Loyal, L-O-Y

ERIC: Loyalty can't afford to be blind. It's earned by good service.

DIANE: You were very well taken care of.

ERIC: Where would I be now if I'd stayed, with Henry ... I'm sorry, by the way. I'm sorry about Henry. Truly.

DIANE: SO sorry they were the first words out of your mouth.

ERIC: I sent a note, you never replied.

DIANE: Why are you here, Eric?

ERIC: You know damn well, why. If you didn't want me here, you could have avoided it with one phone call.

DIANE: I had nothing to say to you.

ERIC: Fine. Then you could simply have packed the pieces up and shipped them to me.

DIANE: Anything belonging to you was returned long ago.

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ERIC: Not the four black paintings.

DIANE: The portraits, you mean?

ERIC: They're not portraits.

DIANE: Funny, they used to be. Odd how much a work can change, years after being completed.

ERIC: Just because a work is inspired by a living subject does not make it a portrait. Don't pretend to such simple-minded ideas.

DIANE: They don't belong to you.

ERIC: I made them.

DIANE: You made many things which no longer belong to you.

ERIC: For which I was compensated.

DIANE: You want money?

ERIC: I want what's mine. Your father knew those works were only for safe-keeping.

DIANE: You didn't give them to Henry. You gave them to me.

ERIC: Never. You invented that and now you've convinced yourself it's true, but I never said it. We've been through all of this.

DIANE: That's right, we have. That's why I didn't return your calls.

ERIC: And the facts haven't changed. What do you think, that I'm just going to give up, that you can outlast me? The next step is lawyers. You understand that, I hope.

DIANE: I'd be pretty stupid if I didn't, since you've threatened it in every message.

ERIC: Is that what you want?

DIANE: You're too cheap to hire a lawyer.

ERIC: Helen's already found me one.

DIANE: Helen, of course. You just go from one nursemaid to another. Tell me, now that it doesn't matter anymore: Were you already sleeping with her before you left

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us?

ERIC: I am not sleeping with her.

DIANE: Really? And here I thought she slept with all her clients. She's clearly not the full-service provider you expected.

ERIC: Do you really want to be throwing rocks in that particular neighborhood?

DIANE: Oh, I assure you I have nothing on Helen. You were my sole mistake in that area. And my last.

ERIC: Why do you have to make it like this?

DIANE: Me? Why do I have to -

ERIC: People have affairs, they end, they move on.

DIANE: This is not about that.

ERIC: Then what the hell is it about?

DIANE: What you did to my father.

ERIC: I did not do anything to your father.

DIANE: Just broke his heart, that's all. Just destroyed his will to fight.

ERIC: I made a business decision. An artist has the right to make a change when his gallery can no longer place his work.

DIANE: An artist has a duty to know when his work has become inferior and repetitive, and to take a hard look inside himself.

ERIC: Interesting that you never made those critiques when they might have mattered.

DIANE: As if you would have listened.

ERIC: That's not the point, is it?

DIANE: You're right. I could see it happening and I said nothing. I was a coward. I didn't want to scare you away. Sue me.

ERIC: Give me my Goddamn paintings, Diane. *(He slams his hand down on the box, then sees it for the first time.)* What is this?

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DIANE: Ashes.

ERIC: *(Backing away.)* That's not Henry, is it?

DIANE: He wanted to be scattered on the beach, at sunrise. Sunrises are beautiful out here, not that I've seen many. But he was always up before dawn, city or country. Drinking coffee while the world slept, calling his pals in London. Thinking about what he could do that day to help his artists.

ERIC: He did me a lot of good, I'd never say otherwise. He loved painters, not these idiots with their videos and shellacked cow intestines. I've missed him this past year. Missed both of you.

DIANE: How sweet.

ERIC: But he'd lost his touch, or maybe he was just tired. He only had time for Sam, Masako, fucking Reinhardt. I barely spoke to him those last few months.

DIANE: Because he knew I was taking care of you. Who sold your last half dozen pieces?

ERIC: It was his gallery.

DIANE: I did.

ERIC: I needed his attention, his approval.

DIANE: And I would have continued to look after you long after Henry was gone.

ERIC: It wasn't the same. I mean, I'm grateful, especially since it turns out you were selling work you clearly hated.

DIANE: That's not what I said.

ERIC: But how long ago were those sales?

DIANE: How many pieces has Helen sold for you?

ERIC: I hear Reinhardt left. Went to Gagosian.

DIANE: Good riddance.

ERIC: And Sam's thinking about it.

DIANE: Not that he's told me. But if it's true, at least he had the decency to wait until Henry died.

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ERIC: SO if I'd waited a year I'd be off the hook?

DIANE: No.

ERIC: Why?

DIANE: You don't listen. Because I was the one taking care of you.

ERIC: You see, this *is* about you and me. You're lying to yourself, using Henry as a shield.

DIANE: Get out of my house, Eric.

ERIC: Look, we all loved you, loved having you involved in our business. You were the strong right hand the old guy needed. But Henry ... Henry was irreplaceable.

DIANE: Apparently not.

ERIC: *(Long pause.)* One piece.

DIANE: One piece of what?

ERIC: What you asked before. Helen sold one piece from the last show. And I haven't even been paid for it.

DIANE: Poor you.

ERIC: Made me wonder about leaving Henry, leaving you. It's always easier to blame someone else. I really thought this was strong stuff. I got rid of all of that blue and yellow I was using, all those bright colors and geometric shapes. Went back to the black and white, the semi-abstract forms.

DIANE: I saw the show.

ERIC: You did? Then you know where I'm going with this. Simple, rigorous, tough, it just poured out of me. Best work in years. And nobody bought it. Got three small, mediocre reviews. I was in a rage, you remember my rages?

DIANE: Yes.

ERIC: And then I walked through the gallery, right before they took the show down. Really looked at each piece. And it was all garbage. Empty canvases. At best, a memory of something good I'd once done, but not the thing itself.

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That's why I need the black paintings back. I haven't done anything like those since, but maybe they'll help me remember how.

DIANE: It doesn't work like that.

ERIC: How the hell would you know?

DIANE: They're creatures of the time in which you created them. They're dead to you now. What's good, what's real, lives in your fingers, in your muscle memory. In your instinct, if you could clear away all the expectations and bullshit.

ERIC: Maybe you're right.

DIANE: The paintings themselves would only be a burden to you.

ERIC: I still want them.

DIANE: Do you really? Is that really why you came?

ERIC: Why else?

DIANE: Maybe to say you were sorry, or that you made a mistake, or that you still ...

ERIC: I'm sorry I hurt you. And I probably did make a mistake, but it's one I plan to live with.

DIANE: Well good for you.

ERIC: Can I have my paintings?

DIANE: Sure.

ERIC: Thank you. Thank you, Diane. This may sound inappropriate, but I'm going to ask anyway. I want to be there when you scatter Henry's ashes. It would mean a lot to me.

DIANE: Sorry. We scattered them yesterday morning. Just my sister, me, and Sam. It was a lovely moment.

ERIC: T hen what's in the box?

DIANE: Your paintings. Your four black paintings. There's a note, too, I was about to send them to you.

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ERIC: This is not even funny.

DIANE: They burned beautifully. You were the one to tell me there's no such thing as black paint, the artist chooses his dark pigments, and you can see it if you look closely. Black may be the absence of all light, but it's the presence of all color, yes? And I could see all of those colors in the flames, a jet of blue, of purple, a sudden burst of green. I know they're not portraits, but I could see my face in every one, black becoming rainbow ore, becoming ash. It was cleansing. I did it right out there on the patio, last night. You can still see the scorch marks.

ERIC: *(Rushing to the door and then stopping.)* You're lying. You would never do that to art, it's not in you.

DIANE: There's a bottom corner of one that survived. It's right on top, just open the flaps and see. Go ahead. A little courage is required in this life.

ERIC: No.

DIANE: Take the box, then. Open it at your leisure.

ERIC: I'll take everything you own. The gallery will collapse overnight when people hear about this.

DIANE: I'm closing the gallery, and moving back to London. My lawyers will know where to find me.

ERIC: How can you possibly justify this?

DIANE: Besides your killing my father? To set myself free. To set us both free. Someday you'll thank me.

ERIC: Someday you'll understand what you've done, and why.

DIANE: Don't forget your paintings.

ERIC: Keep them. They really do resemble you now. *(Exits)*

DIANE: *(Staring at the box.)* Don't look at me like that. I had a right. He'll get over it. He gets over everything, that's his problem. Me, I can't let anything go,

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or anyone. *(Placing her hand on the box.)* But I will. Tomorrow, at sunrise.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil Olson
Book: 2006: The Best Ten-Minute Plays for Two Actors
ISBN: 978-1575255637
Publisher: Smith & Kraus, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2007

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